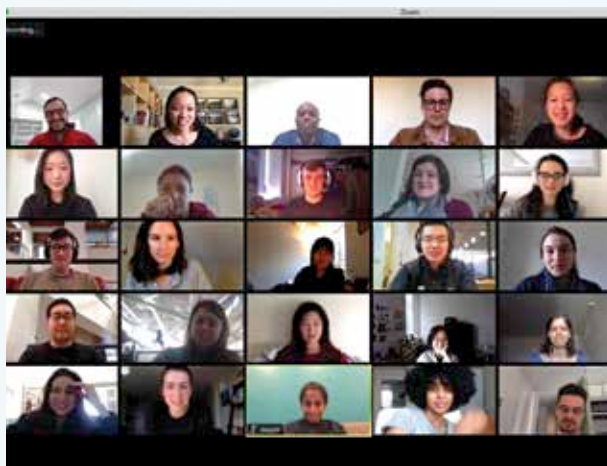




We predict a lot more zombies in the future

generation you belong to, you might find yourself spending far more time on chat applications than social media to begin with. This is because the constant thirst for news that older people have is being replaced with a craving for timepass, fun and creativity. Skills and developing them are being given a lot more preference over simple news. As we have said earlier as well, people have found that kids today are moving away from anonymity online and towards actually getting to know people and making friends. For many kids, especially thanks to the pandemic and the long lasting effects it will have, socialising is done almost exclusively online now. With even school or college classes being held on Zoom or some other video app, kids are going to grow up not being camera shy, and used to meeting new people on video itself. This will then lead to meeting IRL, which is what will be valued. Some studies have suggested that kids in the west are moving back towards forming “real relationships” with peers and local friends, rather than seek a dopamine rush from strangers online. They’re a lot smarter than our generations, we have to admit that.

With the Next Billion coming online, and a significant chunk of that being from India, we are going to be a special case study that will mimic the whole rest of the world in a way. While different countries speak different languages in most parts of the world, in India you can get a different language, often by travelling just a couple of hundred kilometres in any direction. Thus, studying how localized solutions work in India is going to be the smarter way to plan for a globe that doesn’t all speak the same language. The difference between the way a Marathi social network is used, over a Malayalam one, will teach researchers some valuable lessons in how to better manage the differences between a German localised social network and a Spanish one.

TEXT IS DEAD

It obviously isn’t, but this is a much better headline for this section than “Text will decline or stagnate”, right? As internet speeds get better across the world, and as more and more people come online, text is just not going to cut it anymore. We run a WhatsApp number as a helpline for those looking to subscribe to our digital edition, or those

who have trouble accessing it, and more often than not we get people just sending us audio. This is because they do it in their language, and technology is just not as good as making a keyboard for different languages as it is for English. This is a trend that we see increasing as more and more people come online. While many people will still be shy to appear on video, especially in our country, they’re not at all shy of using voice to communicate.

While video increasing in popularity as a medium of communication and social sharing is a no-brainer, we think voice will increase exponentially to the point where it will eventually challenge text as the default method of communication. Of course it might need the Boomer and the Gen X generations to die out first, but it’s coming.

NICHES

The reason we used it in our headline for this cover story, is our definition of the word “microsocial”. It literally means small social or small community, or relating to society in small groups, but we meant it more like “smaller social media services”. In a way, we mean smaller social groups will form and social media will be fragmented into niches that serve a more specific purpose. Of course the word niche usually means small, and we want to clarify that we don’t mean that as insignificant. While new social media services will not have a billion users like the behemoths, they will have hundreds of thousands or even a few million users. In essence, we will see a return to the good old discussion forum days, where we formed groups based on interest and exchanged ideas and thoughts about those interests.

The Digit Forum is exactly that for (mostly) PC technology, so if you’re interested in PCs, give it a whirl.

Of course we will be utterly shocked if the world returned to the forum experience of discussions, because attention spans are short and the average temperament of kids is moving increasingly towards more impatience. So it will probably be something we have never seen before, and perhaps even using some service is an innovative way that it wasn’t specifically designed for. What will not change anytime soon is the fact that there are only 24 hours in a day, and between a kid’s wholesome life of gaming, study and outdoors, the more things a child does, the less time they have to spend on something pointless like today’s social media services. In a society where niche interest areas are not just supported, but actually encouraged, kids are just not going to have time for anything generic. YouTube is going to be very important to kids though, because somehow it is a platform that never seems to get tarnished for being too generalised. While kids already consider Facebook to be for old people, they happily flock to YouTube because it’s considered to be a mere platform instead of a social media network like Facebook is.

In the end Mark Zuckerberg’s biggest mistake might be allowing the brand Facebook to get a name and a face, and trying to stand for something, instead of blending into the background as a “service” like YouTube did. At least that’s our prediction, for whatever little it’s worth.